Beria is a misleading precedent; he was a part of Stalin's state apparatus, during twenty years of collectivisation, war and final paranoia. Andropov has no such image. The Chinese parallel is important; the Chinese have adopted the Soviet model and their Minister for Public Security corresponds to the Soviet KGB chief. Hua Kuo Feng became Supreme leader after being the security chief. No one batted an eyelid either in China or in the democratic West.

The R&AW analysis of India's position was proved correct during Indira Gandhi's visit to Moscow to attend Brezhnev's funeral. She met Andropov, now the leader of the Soviet Union, and the two reaffirmed their mutual desire to further strengthen friendship and cooperation between their countries.

Though the analysis of the repercussions of the power struggle in the Soviet Union seems quite simple and straightforward, it was and remains the most delicate task undertaken by the intelligence agency, given that the intelligence was related to a friendly power rather than an enemy state.

A Third Alternative in the UK

Intelligence analysis also looks into new security or political coalitions shaping up in countries of interests. The analysts use their bird's eye view to keep track of the competitive market economy, internal political struggles, changing social dynamics and strength and weaknesses of foreign countries to be able to coherently warn the executive of possible issues. In the 1980s, R&AW officers and analysts watching developments in the UK were pleasantly surprised when a new political outfit called the Social Democratic Party (SDP) was formed after four powerful members of the Labour Party decided to provide an alternative against Prime Minister Margaret Thatcher's Conservative Party.